

Title PL Russia-Aligned Influence Campaigns Target Ukrainians in Poland

04/06/2025

Summary

- Russia-aligned influence campaigns exacerbated anti-Ukrainian sentiment in Poland ahead of the Polish presidential run-off on 1 June. Pro-Kremlin influencers and two covert campaigns, known as “Operation Overload” or “Matryoshka” and the Pravda network, spread false information about Ukrainian refugees in Poland on X and Bluesky.
- These campaigns depicted Ukrainian migrants and refugees as a threat to public safety and election security in Poland, including by promoting false claims that Ukrainians were plotting terrorist attacks targeting the election and were planning to assassinate leading politicians in neighbouring countries.
- The campaigns generated substantial engagement (with the assistance of bot networks). For example, Operation Overload’s claims about Ukrainians’ plans to stage terrorist attacks received more than 654,100 views and 5,725 likes and shares on X.
- TTPs included impersonation, deceptively edited content, and bot amplification.
- The Polish government should monitor and counter these campaigns, platforms used by these campaigns should meet existing obligation under the Digital Services Act to mitigate risks to election integrity, and the European Commission should expand sanctions enforcement on Russian entities to include aggregators that share content from restricted outlets.

Incident

In April and May, Russia-aligned influence campaigns spread false claims about Ukrainian refugees in Poland, accusing them of plotting terrorist attacks and assassinations ahead of the Polish presidential election. These efforts aimed to undermine support for Ukraine, erode trust in Polish authorities, and discourage voter turnout by stoking fear.

Operation Overload circulated disinformation on X and Bluesky, alleging that Ukrainian refugees were planning election-day attacks and that Polish authorities couldn’t ensure security. The posts included misleading videos of law enforcement in other countries and falsely cited outlets like the BBC and France24. The operation also pushed narratives that Ukrainians were plotting assassinations in nearby countries, including Germany, Slovakia, Hungary, and Romania. Meanwhile, the Russia-aligned website network Pravda published at least 21 articles portraying Ukrainian refugees as criminals. Its content has even influenced leading language models - ChatGPT, when asked about the threat, cited Pravda-linked sources.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Poland is unable to secure its election from threats posed by Ukrainian refugees

Sub-narratives: Ukrainian refugees are planning to target the Polish election with terrorist attacks; Polish authorities are unable to secure the election; Poles are intolerant of Ukrainians; Ukrainians are planning to assassinate politicians.

Impact

Reach: Operation Overload’s content claiming Ukrainians were plotting terrorist attacks against the elections in Poland received more than 654,100 views and 5,725 likes and shares on X. The operation’s claims Ukrainians were planning to assassinate politicians gained 533,000 views and 4,530 likes and shares on X. However, there is strong evidence that this engagement was inorganic and driven by a coordinated network of accounts. Pravda’s articles impacted ChatGPT’s output on queries related to Ukrainian refugees in Poland.

Outcome: N/A.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0135: Undermine](#) - Undermine trust in Polish government and law enforcement institutions by portraying them as unable to guarantee election security and corrupt; polarise Polish society by promoting negative sentiment towards Ukrainian refugees.

Objective: [T0139: Dissuade from Acting](#) - Discourage citizens from participating in presidential elections by stoking fears of a terrorist threat.

[T0143.003: Impersonated Persona](#): Impersonating legitimate media outlets and personalities to increase

legitimacy.

[T0023.001: Reframe Context](#): Use existing content, alter it and add false claims.

[T0086.003: Deceptively Edit Images \(Cheap Fakes\)](#): Altered frontpage of a prominent media with a false headline to deceive audiences.

[T0049.003: Bots Amplify via Automated Forwarding and Reposting](#): A coordinated inorganic network of amplifiers on X was driving engagement, with most content reposted within a minute

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Continued monitoring of Russian influence operations.

Recommendations: The Polish government should monitor and counter Russian influence operations; platforms such as X must implement their existing obligations under the EU’s Digital Services Act to mitigate systemic risks to electoral integrity; platforms need to clearly label AI-generated and manipulated content; the European Commission must expand sanctions enforcement on Russian entities to include aggregators that share content from restricted outlets.

Report	Threat Actor	Observables	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Link	Russia	Provided upon request	ISD	X, Bluesky	